Fall/Winter, 2003/2004 Volume VI, Issue 2/3

The Mountainside

www.coolfontmountainside.org

Coolfont Mountainside Association

looking for a few Good Volunteers!

Well, it is indeed that time again. We have about five months to find some new leadership for the Coolfont Mountainside Association. Specifically, your community needs you to volunteer for some of the critically important jobs that need doing to keep our community of more than 120 homes and home sites working smoothly.

As CMA President Richard Kaufman says later in this newsletter, it really is <u>your</u> investment you'll be protecting. By volunteering some of your valuable time to serve on a CMA committee or on the board, you help keep CMA—and your home's value—strong.

The jobs to be done are widely varied, and experience is not necessarily required (we have lots of experienced hands still very active in CMA who can help you learn the ropes of all the jobs available.

Here's a list of jobs for which you may consider volunteering some time, along with rough time requirements, based on current work levels:

CMA Board: *(3 seats to be filled in July)*

Board member: 8-12 hours per month

President: 12—15 + hours per month

Treasurer: 15—20 hours per month

Secretary: 8—10 hours per month

CMA Committees:

Design and Architectural Control Committee (DACC:) Reviews plans, makes site visits, issues approvals and reports to CMA board.

Chair: 6-10 hours per month

Member (3) 4-8 hours per month

Communications Committee: Gets important information to members via email, telephone tree coordination and the newsletter.

Social Committee: Gets Host Volunteers for Potluck Dinners, new member brunch, Pool Beautification Day, etc.

Nominating Committee: Sets rules for CMA elections, encourages CMA members to be candidates for the board, supervises the election at the Annual Meeting.

And there's more! Roads, Security, Recreation! Call any board member for more

CMA Board Meetings and Potluck Dinners!

February 14th
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Thompson R-4

March 13
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: TBD

April 17
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Barn

May 15
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Barn

June 12
Board: CMA Office
Potluck: Barn

July 17
Board: CMA Office
ANNUAL MEETING:
Treetops Lodge
Annual Dinner: Barn

<u>HOST A POTLUCK DINNER!</u>
It's easy, fun and a great way to meet your Coolfont Neighbors!

Call Hallie Kerr, Social Committee Chair for details!

Special Feature!



Winter Driving on the Mountainside

Editor's note: Elmer Broxson graces our pages again with some timely tips on driving on our Mountainside roads. It is my observation that there are two types of drivers among the Mountainside community. Those who have slid off the road, and those who have not slid off the road...yet. Here's Elmer's good counsel:

As was announced at the annual meeting, CMA no longer depends upon the Coolfont resort to plow our roads and members' driveways. The resort does clear the driveways of the approximate 30 members who have a rental contract with the Resort. Because of our good experience last summer and fall with the road upgrade contractor, Robert Snidemiller, we have asked him and his crew to plow our roads. He is also available to plow members' driveways as requested. It is the responsibility of each homeowner to arrange for their own driveway snow removal and you can do so by contacting Snidemiller at (304) 258-4278, or the Coolfont Resort at (304) 258-4500 or anyone else you choose from several in the Berkeley Springs / Morgan County phone book.

Because Snidemiller does not have a mechanical spreader for gravel , we depend on the Coolfont Resort to spread gravel on icy sections of the mountainside roads after each snowfall, under the direction of our Operations Manager, John Hobday.

The routine for snow removal at present is as follows: When a snowfall accumulates more than 3", Snidemiller will plow it to a width of 20 feet wherever possible, but raising the snowplow blade ½" off the surface to avoid damaging the paved or gravel roads. John Hobday then asks the resort o spread gravel. Now that we have the experience of two snow falls, we are asking members for community complaints and / or complements about the present routine. Call either John Hobday at (304) 258-8141, Robert Snidemiller at (304) 258-4278, or Elmer Broxson at (202) 333-8872.

Mountainside Driving Tips, or: Keeping Out of the Woods (while in your car):

In the meantime, it is important to remember that snow and ice are a normal part of winter on the mountainside. These conditions have their attractions and hazards. The more snow and ice there is and the colder the weather, the longer it takes to clear our roads. So please be patient, especially during and after a major snowstorm. During the storm or under icy conditions it is generally a good idea to avoid traveling at all. But if you must drive, here are some suggestions to help you avoid getting stuck.

Just to get to your car, you will need a good, sturdy metal snow shovel, plus sand and/or an ice breaker for any steps. Clearing the car, you'll need a stiff broom, ice scraper and matches or lighter to heat your car key in case the lock is frozen. Some lock anti-freeze solutions work well for that purpose. Regularly make certain that your battery is fully charged. Keep your tires properly inflated. And make sure you have flares, jumper cables, a flashlight, first-aid kit jack, spare tire, blanket, extra wiper fluid, a bag of sand and a snow shovel in the trunk. Sounds like a lot for a weekend trip to Coolfont, but these basics are needed by drivers on the mountainside more than most people realize!

Winter driving on a mountain road is a simple exercise in physics. Gravity wants your car to go downhill in the most direct manner possible (without consideration of whether there is a ditch or trees in the way). Also, do not assume that greater speed on curves or hills will successfully "pull" you through an icy section. It will probably offer just enough momentum to send your car skidding. Don't lock your brakes, though; gently reduce your forward momentum a little at a time.

For loss of traction, keep a 50-pound sack of play sand and small shovel to spread it as needed. It is also a good idea – even if you have a front wheel or all-wheel drive car – to keep your gas tank full before a predicted winter storm, to provide addition vehicle weight for traction.

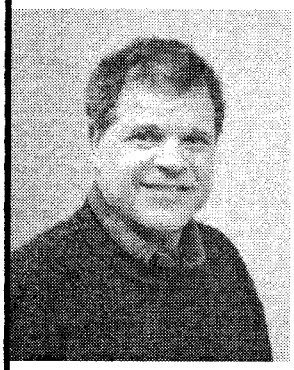
If all that fails, keep a cell phone handy and charged up. Remember, 911 is for emergencies only; AAA is 1-800-222-4357; WV State Police is (304) 258-0000; Morgan County Sheriff is (304)258-1067; 24 hour local road service and towing is Loy's at (304) 258-3559 or Warm Springs Garage at (304) 258-3695.

Drive carefully!

Elmer Broxson

The President's Column

HOW TO PROTECT YOUR INVESTMENT



I spent New Year's Eve on the mountainside partying with friends. We were asked to make up resolutions for others to follow which, of course, is a lot easier than making them up for your self. It was great fun and I couldn't help thinking how fortunate we are to have homes to live in or retreat to in such a lovely place in a community of good and friendly people.

Along with the other attributes of the Coolfont mountainside is the fact that property values have been going up. According to a recent story in the Morgan Messenger, property values in and around Berkeley Springs have tripled in just the past few years. The prices of houses on the mountainside have certainly risen to record levels and the likelihood is that they will keep rising. That means that in addition to our own personal virtues, and our love of woodlands and mountains, we are all clever investors, right? Well, maybe.

We have a beautiful neighborhood to live and recreate in if we can keep it that way. Only God, as they say, can make a tree. But it takes the hard work of people to make a functioning community and a place where people want to go. Our land and home values have consistently exceeded those elsewhere in the county. One reason for this, aside from the natural beauty of the environment and the good location, is the care that has been taken in the physical development and the systems that go into it.

Now, suppose the water and sewer systems stopped functioning, or our roads became so rutted out from water runoff or littered with fallen trees that they could not be used. Suppose the swimming pool was not properly maintained, that water filters were not replaced, and that it was shut down for hygienic reason by local authorities. Or, what if we did not spend the money to build a pool house and we still had to have a jiffy john. What if our building guidelines and regulations were not enforced. How would it be if our common lands were not protected and trees were arbitrarily removed?

I think you get the picture and if you suspect that I am leading up to something, you are correct. Certainly, we are all responsible people who would not spoil a good thing. Because we are so responsible we support the homeowners association to look after the neighborhood. We need the homeowners association and it needs you.

So, please, do yourselves and your property values a favor and become a more active member of the association. It is never too late to make a good New Year's resolution. How about adding to your list a commitment to attend one or more of the monthly meetings of the board of directors and to join one of the committees? If you believe you can improve the way things are done around here, or even of you are satisfied, why not become a candidate for this year's elections to the board?

A personal note: This is my 6th and, under the rules, my final year on the board. So there will be at least one and perhaps other vacancies on the governing body. Turnover is good. It makes room for new faces and new ideas. Whether as a board member or in some other capacity you would be most welcome.

Richard Kaufman

From the Treasurer:
CMA Finances are On Target

Treasurer's report to members:

Now that half of our fiscal year has passed, it is time to review our objectives and how they were met.

As always, I will first discuss the Association's finances and then the financial status of our Water & Sewer System.

The CMA budget had four major projects scheduled for this year. We budgeted $43,000 for the Tennis Courts rehabilitation. It was completed with a 3.8% overrun. All the reports I have heard indicate the rehabilitation and the Sport Court have been well received by our members and we look forward to using the tennis facilities heavily in the spring. The road widening and improvement project had a budget of $51,000. The initial portion of this task has now been completed and funds remain available for the final phase to be completed this Spring. We expect the Roads Capital expenditures to come in within the budget. The third project called for finding a replacement firm or individual to provide snow plowing when necessary and at a reasonable cost. This has been done and you all have been made aware of our arrangement with Robert Snidemiller for plowing individual driveways. We were pleased with the way the plowing was done during the December snows. The fourth project, resolving our security service problem remains unresolved. The response to the questionnaire recently sent by Cindy Van Meter should help us solve this matter within budget constraints. To accomplish all these tasks we have had to draw approximately $33,400 from our reserves. Despite this drawdown I fully expect to finish the year within the approved budget which called for using $53,000 from reserves.

In conclusion the financial position of the Association remains strong. All assessments have been paid although two members have not paid the late fee or interest which is assessed when payments are paid late. Steps are being taken to collect these amounts.

The Water & Sewer budget had as its basis, maintaining the system so as to provide good service to our members. To this extent, we have completed the first stage of sub-metering the system to enable us to identify leaks and control the system. The system is maintained by our Operations Manager, John D. Hobday, who does yeoman service for us and is available to assist any member with problems relating to the system.

With six months of the year completed we have collected 46% of the budgeted revenue and paid 46% of the budgeted expense.

We continue to recognize a confusion with the billing among our members. Some of you may have received both an Invoice and a Statement when we bill. The Invoice represents new billing. The Statement is only sent when you have a prior credit or a prior unpaid bill or a prior unpaid late fee. It summarizes the activity in your account. If you receive a Statement, please pay the amount shown as balance due on the Statement. The Invoice and Statement are NOT two bills. The first is a current bill the other is what you owe. If your account is clear and there is no prior balance or prior credit, we will not send a Statement.

I want to thank those members who make my job a pleasure by paying their assessments and water bills in a timely manner. I am concerned that after each quarter's water bill is rendered, approximately 10-20 members do not pay on time. Not only does it cost them a 10% penalty, but it makes the job of the volunteer Treasurer more time consuming. I urge each of you to pay promptly, thereby avoiding the penalty and making my job easier.

At this time I am looking for someone to assist me with the activities of the Treasurer, someone who would serve as an Assistant Treasurer and learn our accounting system and procedures. You may be aware that our By-laws and Covenant prohibit a member from serving on the Board more than three terms (six years) consecutively. My three terms will be up in June 2005. Now is the time for someone to come forward so that the Association's finances can continue to be managed without a loss of continuity. I will be available to assist my successor in the future.

As always, I am ready to respond to any questions you may have about the financial condition of the Association or its Water and Sewer system.

Paul D. Kagen



Development and Architectural Control Committee (DACC)



At the December Board meeting, the long-awaited update to the Regulations and Guidelines for Building at Coolfont was approved by the Board after thorough review and should be ready for issue soon. Of note: we have incorporated the Fire Wise guidance into the regulations to allow the safest possible environment for homes at Coolfont.

We have had some changes in DACC membership with Linda Dunyan, Chuck Braun, Richard Kaufmann and me now serving as your DACC Committee.

New houses are now complete at K-1, K-2 and T-8, progress continues at T-6 and construction has been approved for E-3 and T-5. I expect by springtime we will have some new homes and many renovation projects presented for review.

Please contact me with any questions or comments.

Jim Thompson
DACC Chair
2748 S. Grove St.
Arlington, VA 22202-2424
703-684-8465

New Tennis Courts - Now Open!



Have you seen the new Sport Court and our refurbished tennis courts yet? They are in place and they are very well done! The regular courts have been totally resurfaced and painted, and the new Sport Court offers many options for net play, plus half-court basketball and even shuffleboard. The net height is adjustable all the way up to regulation volleyball height.



Access to the courts is available to all Coolfont members and their guests. The courts will be locked at all times to prevent damage to them, but all CMA members will soon be sent a free special key to unlock the doors at the steps leading up from the parking area. PLEASE KEEP THIS KEY SECURE! New keys can only be made by the original lock manufacturer, and are costly (your cost for replacements). We recommend connecting the key to a large object (block of wood, truck tire, your dog , etc.) to insure it does not get lost.

Members are asked to pick up all trash after use of the courts, depositing it at your own home. If you have guests, please remind them of this request. Enjoy!

TIMEWARP



By Cindy Van Meter

We sat with our eyes riveted to the monitor, wondering if we should make the two-hour journey to Berkeley Springs. After all, weather forecasters were predicting snow with temperatures plummeting to nearly zero. Forecasts for bone-chilling temperatures and precipitation were further confirmed by tuning into Bob Borcher's weather station - at the Coolfont web site [www.coolfontmountainside.org or at www.bborchers.com]. But, hey, we could be resourceful if necessary. The drive would only take two hours. We were looking forward to a relaxing four-day weekend and a CMA potluck dinner where there is always friendship, enjoyment and very good food. So, even though we had some reservations, we ventured forth to Berkeley Springs.

As we drove north along dry Virginia and West Virginia roads, we became more convinced that our decision was the right one. Then DISASTER STRUCK! It was almost 8:00 p.m. when we arrived at our house, and there was no hot water!! In addition, our heat pump wasn't cooperating and the temperature just wouldn't rise above 58 degrees until two days later. Since local hardware stores were closed, our only option for purchasing a hot water heating element was to race to Lowe's in Martinsburg. *Success*! Lowe's had the needed heating element! Joe was now promising that he'd have the water heater repaired in time for me to take that long awaited warm shower. The heating element was installed (after a slight miscalculation that caused ICE COLD water to gush out of the hot water tank and onto the basement floor). Joe scurried around, looking for mops, buckets, and just anything that would catch the gushing water, while I, like the Little Dutch Boy, tried to hold back the flow with my hands and what was left of the heating element.

Finally, the water stopped flowing and with the help of a few towels that will *never* be used for their intended purpose, we dried the floor, and Joe installed the heating element. Joe smiled confidently, like only a husband can, as he cheerfully told me that in a few minutes I would be taking that long awaited shower. It was not meant to be! It turns out there are TWO heating elements in the tank, both of which failed. You can imagine my "joy" at heating water on the stove to take a sponge bath; after all I was in the house *not on a camping trip*!

The next day, Joe and I attended the CMA Board meeting, got some plumbing wisdom from John Hobday, made another trip to the hardware store, and re-drained the hot water tank *(This time there was no miscalculation!).* It was *late* Saturday evening before we had hot water. House temperature was still in the 50s. Outside temperature dropped to 12 degrees, snow was falling and roads were icy. We were now snow and ice-bound, satellite TV dropped out due to heavy snowfall, and TV reception was limited to only one local station. Our vision of an enjoyable weekend just "melted" away.

On Monday, as we drove along route 522 toward home, we felt we were in a time warp. There was no sign of snow. We were kept warm by the car's heater. The roads and surrounding landscape were gray and bleak. While Joe drove, I closed my eyes and immediately had visions of icy tree branches glistening like thousands of diamonds outside our windows. I could smell comfort food cooking in the oven, and feel the oven's warmth. I envisioned hardy CMA members braving the ice and cold to gather for an enjoyable evening at Kevin Spitler and Karen Anderson's home. Last but not least, I could feel the warmth of our duvet as Joe and I cuddled to keep warm. It was then that I realized *our weekend didn't melt away – It was pretty good after all!*

Restaurant Review: The Lockhouse—Hancock, MD

The Lockhouse Restaurant in Hancock re-opened on December 16, under the direction of manager and chef Tom Lombardo, and his partner, sous chef and business manager Sandy Hinds. Many CMA regulars remember the restaurant as "Sculley's", where the chief attraction was their recipe for ribs. Now, Lombardo has move the menu to a more mainstream, wide-ranging selection, with just a few imaginative offerings. Four of us went to the restaurant on a recent Saturday night, and left —in a word—disappointed. The service was friendly but ill-trained, with the waitress suggesting to one of the diners that if they needed to know what kind of beer was served, they should get up and go into the bar and look. All of the four entrees were served lukewarm, and the two filets ordered were miniscule and overcooked. The chef is using far too much salt in all the dishes we tried, and the sauces were equally briny. We did not try the desserts, although the tray of selections brought to the table looked attractive. Perhaps we'll try next time, when the staff has been trained, the chef has put away the Morton's box, and the food can wait under a heat lamp for pickup by the waitress.

GRADE: C-

Jackson Bain